

Day 1 — “IKS”: What Does the Term Refer To?

Module: What is IKS? (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students engage the boundary problem — what “IKS” denotes, what it doesn’t, and why the label itself is a recent construction.

Materials

- NEP 2020 §4.6 printed extract
- Whiteboard

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Provocation: “‘*Indian Knowledge Systems*’ — is that a coherent category, or a political slogan?”

Take 3 student answers. Don’t correct.

Core (25 min)

1. **The term “IKS” is recent.** Started gaining traction post-2000, codified by NEP 2020 §4.6. The *contents* — Vedic literature, Sāṅkhya philosophy, Pāṇini’s grammar, Bhāskara’s mathematics, Patañjali’s yoga, etc. — are millennia old.
2. **The boundary problem:**
 - Is “Buddhism” IKS? (Originated in India; spread to East Asia and beyond.)
 - Is “Sanskrit poetics” IKS? (Yes, but it’s also “Sanskrit literature.”)
 - Is “Mughal architecture” IKS? (Mixed Persianate-Indic; depends on definition.)
 - Is “Vedic mathematics” (Tirthaji 1965) IKS? (20th-c. synthesis with Vedic *label*.)
3. **Three honest framings to choose from** (write on board):

Framing	Strength	Weakness
“IKS = pre-modern Indian intellectual production”	Inclusive	Vague boundaries
“IKS = canonical Brahmanical knowledge systems”	Specific	Excludes Buddhist, Tantric, regional
“IKS = anything taught under the NEP §4.6 umbrella”	Operational	Political construction; varies by implementer

Each is defensible. Pick one knowingly, not by default.

4. **Read aloud NEP 2020 §4.6.** Discuss: what does the policy say IKS should include? What does it leave open?

Discussion (10 min)

Open question: “Which framing would you use in your paper? Why?”

Take 4 student positions.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 2: “Tomorrow — we read primary sources. *Ṛg Veda 1.1* and *Īśa Upaniṣad*.”

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read Pollock (2006) ch. 1 on Sanskrit as cosmopolitan language.
- **Tier down:** Focus on the three framings; don’t worry about the policy text yet.

Teacher notes

- Some students will immediately want to “defend Indian culture” against perceived critique. Reframe: precise definition IS defending it. Imprecise defence weakens.
- Some will want to dismiss the whole module as “Hindu nationalism.” Push: scholarly framing exists; engage it.

Citation(s) used

- Government of India (2020). NEP 2020 §4.6.
- vidya-karana RAG cache day-01-intro.json for background.